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Dangers of the sea

> 9.1 Jaws

Language focus

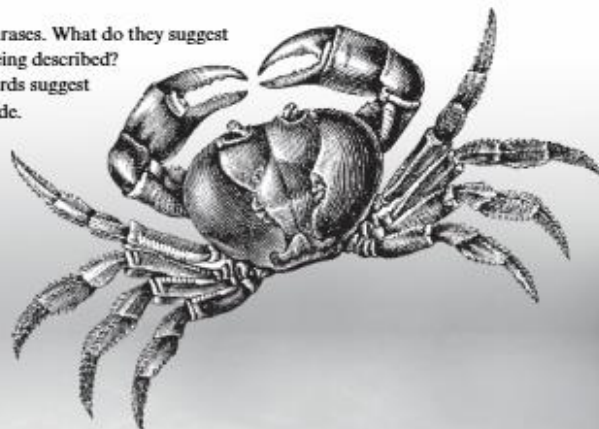
Writers choose words and phrases to portray the appearance and manner of their characters. By using language carefully to suggest small details such as colours, sounds and movement, writers can imply things about their characters' personality and attitudes. For example, the following description of a wolf uses words and phrases to suggest certain qualities about the animal:

As it came around the corner, the deep black eyes of the animal seemed to get darker. The wolf stopped and stood completely still. Now and again, its nose twitched. It stared. Slowly, it crouched, waiting to pounce. Its jaw opened slightly and as it leapt, it let out a fierce growl from its black throat.

The use of dark colours suggests something dangerous about the wolf. The words used to describe movement are contrasting: they focus on the stillness of the animal, which seems threatening, and then the verb 'leapt' suggests the wolf's power. Its growl is described as 'fierce', which also suggests dangerous power. Together, these words present an animal that appears threatening and fearsome.

Focus

- 1 Look at the following phrases. What do they suggest about the sea creature being described? Think about how the words suggest personality and/or attitude. Complete the table.



Sentence	What is being suggested
The sea-horse glided majestically through the water.	The use of 'glided' implies a gracefulness about the creature. 'Majestically' has connotations of power and status.
The sunlight pierced the water revealing the beautiful blue and green scales of the fish.	
Slowly and menacingly, the lobster plotted its way along the sea bed.	

Practice

- 2 Read the following extract about Hooper's encounter with the shark in *Jaws* by Peter Benchley. Underline key words and phrases that suggest the shark's power and personality.

The fish slid backward out of the cage and turned sharply to the right in a tight circle. Hooper then saw the wide gap in the bars and saw the giant head **lunging** through it. He raised his hands above his head, grasping at the escape **hatch**.

The fish **rammed** through the space between the bars, spreading them still farther with each thrust of its tail. Hooper, flattened against the back of the cage, saw the mouth reaching, straining for him. He remembered the head, and he tried to lower his right arm and grab it. The fish thrust again.

lunging: moving downwards quickly and forcefully
hatch: a small entrance
rammed: pushed violently

Write a paragraph explaining how the writer's word choices create an impression of the shark's power.

- Clearly state the impression created.
- Use the examples you have found, commenting on the effect created.
- Identify word classes and language techniques.

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Challenge

- 3 Invent a new type of sea creature. Start by imagining its size, shape and colour. Is it threatening or beautiful? What name would you give it? Write a description of your creature, focusing on small details such as colours, sounds and movement. Choose words and phrases that will give your reader a sense of the creature's qualities and appearance.

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> 9.2 Victims and villains

One of the structural decisions a writer has to make is what each character knows about the situation they are in. They also need to choose how much information to give the reader. For example, if the reader knows that a character is in danger, it creates tension – especially if the character is unaware of it.

Focus

- 1 Here are three paragraphs from a short story about a sailor. In the right-hand column, note down what information is kept from the reader in each paragraph. The first one has been done for you.

Paragraph content	What information the reader doesn't know
1 A sailor receives a letter telling him to arrive at the harbour to get on his boat the following morning with a packed suitcase.	Who the sailor is, why he has been sent the letter, who has sent it.
2 The sailor meets a friend that evening. They talk about a dangerous sea captain they both know. The friend knows a secret about the sea captain.	
3 The next morning, the sea captain is waiting on the ship in the harbour. He has an angry look on his face. The sailor hasn't arrived.	

Practice

- 2 Read the following story. Identify what the boy (Will), his father (Peter) and the reader do and do not know in each paragraph. Complete the table.

As he walked home from school, Will wondered what his dad was doing. His dad, Peter, had gone on a business trip and was due to be away for another six months. Will missed his dad. He loved his mother, but his dad was like an older, cool brother.

When Will was young, his family had moved to a large, beautiful house. It had cost a lot of money, and his dad had taken a well-paid job, which meant lots of time away from home. However, as Will walked home from school, he didn't know that at that very moment, his dad was sitting at home. It was Will's birthday and Peter had flown home to surprise him.

Will pushed through the door and put his schoolbag down. As he walked into the room, there was his dad, arms wide open. Will ran into them and shed a quiet tear. Peter did too, but Will didn't notice. It was a great surprise, but Peter had an even bigger one for Will – next month, he was returning for good.

Paragraph	Will's knowledge	Peter's knowledge	Reader's knowledge
1			
2			
3			

Challenge

- 3 Write a paragraph featuring two characters who know different things about a situation. You could set it at sea or somewhere else. Start by choosing a situation and characters. For example, it could be a teacher and a learner discussing missing homework. Remember you need to decide how much to tell the reader.

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> 9.3 Fear!

In an informative article, paragraphs may serve different purposes. For example, the opening paragraph is often designed to 'hook' the reader – to attract their interest and make them want to read on. Later paragraphs might be intended to give readers advice.

Focus

Sentences containing advice can be written as imperatives (also called directives or commands). These are sentences that give orders. The subject is usually left out of an imperative sentence ('Wear a life jacket') but sometimes the subject is included ('You must wear a life jacket').

- 1 Read the following six sentences. Tick the three imperative sentences.

- Never pick up a jellyfish. ☐
- Whales are huge sea creatures. ☐
- The sea covers much of the globe. ☐
- Always take care when swimming. ☐
- We must look after our planet. ☐
- Should we go sailing? ☐

Practice

- 2 Advice can also be given in a less direct way. Read this article about facing your fears. Underline the key pieces of advice.

Overcoming Your Fears

Everybody has things they fear. It might be animals, small spaces or the dark. How can you overcome these fears? There's no easy solution but you might start by talking about them. Rather than pretending your fears don't exist, talk to a friend about them. Find a comfortable place and explain clearly how you feel. You could also explore why you are afraid – did something happen to make you feel that way? Is there a logical reason for your fear?



A more extreme way to face your fear is to face it. To do this, you need to be very brave. If you're frightened of the dark, spend short amounts of time with the lights off. Remember to breathe and remember that you are in control. Another way of confronting your fears is to write about them. There are plenty of people with similar fears. Why not find others online who share your worries and help each other? If your fears are really affecting your life, remember that your doctor will always be able to offer advice and further support.

Challenge

- 3 Taking information and condensing it into notes is an important skill. To do this, you must make sure you understand the main ideas of a text.

Read the following extract from an article by Elaina Zachos, which gives a different view of sharks to the ones you have read so far.

You should:

- identify the main reasons why humans should not view sharks as dangerous villains
- use this information to write a paragraph in your notebook titled 'A different view of sharks'.

Why are we afraid of sharks?

The number of shark attacks per year is increasing, but this isn't in line with the **skyrocketing** human population. Of the 80-odd shark attacks that happen each year, **fatality** rates are decreasing. It's difficult to count sharks says Blake Chapman, a shark expert, but it appears their numbers are decreasing. To meet the demand for shark fin soup, some fishermen in Asia will catch sharks, chop off their fins, and then release them back into the water to die.

Studies have shown that shark populations can have an effect on sea grass composition and the presence of other animals in a habitat. Sharks are also being studied for cancer treatments.

skyrocketing:
increasing in
huge numbers
fatality: death

> 9.4 A tale of a whale

When written accurately and realistically, dialogue can bring stories and characters to life.

Focus

- 1 Write down four rules for setting out speech.

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Practice

- 2 Dialogue can reveal information and show relationships between characters. It can indicate who is in charge and how characters are feeling.
- Underline all the dialogue in this extract of *And The Ocean Was Our Sky* by Patrick Ness.
 - Complete the table to show what the dialogue reveals about the personalities and emotions of the three characters.

'Bathsheba!' the Captain called from what was now below me. 'Has he recovered?'

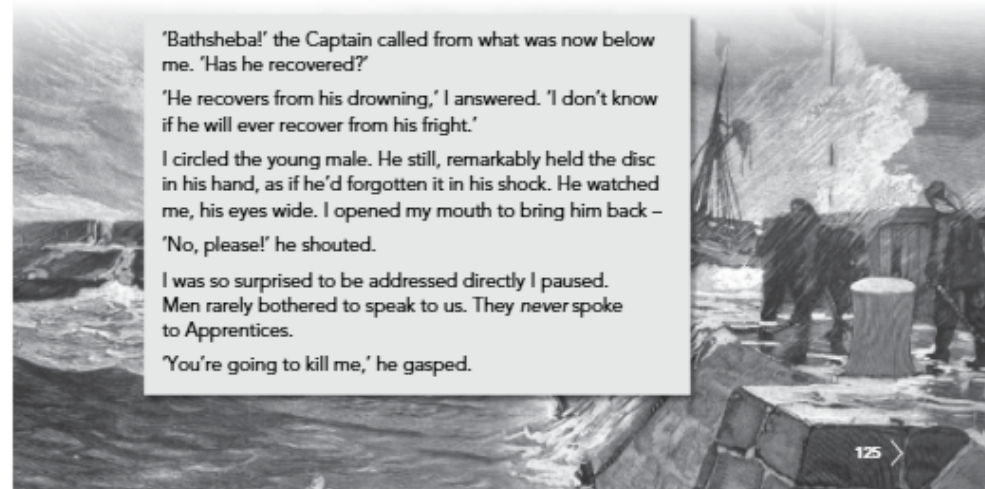
'He recovers from his drowning,' I answered. 'I don't know if he will ever recover from his fright.'

I circled the young male. He still, remarkably held the disc in his hand, as if he'd forgotten it in his shock. He watched me, his eyes wide. I opened my mouth to bring him back –

'No, please!' he shouted.

I was so surprised to be addressed directly I paused. Men rarely bothered to speak to us. They never spoke to Apprentices.

'You're going to kill me,' he gasped.



Character	What the dialogue reveals about them
The Captain	
Bathsheba	
The young male	

Challenge

- 3 A writer has to decide which parts of their story to tell through dialogue and which parts to narrate. Rewrite the following examples of narrated stories to include dialogue. You will have to use your imagination!

- a I looked at Jamil angrily. He told me the real reason why he no longer wanted to be my friend. I told him how that made me feel.

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- b I asked my friend to tell me her favourite memory from her childhood. She told me about a trip she went on at school.

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- c Chen directed the boat into the storm. Jian was worried and asked him lots of questions. Chen answered some of them.

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> 9.5 The Rime of the Ancient Mariner 1

In *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* by Samuel Taylor Coleridge, the poet offers vivid details about the Mariner's appearance, the wedding guest and the suffering of the sailors.

Focus

- 1 The opening of *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* describes how the Mariner meets the wedding guest. Annotate the following lines to note what you discover about the Mariner's appearance.

It is an ancient Mariner,

By thy long grey beard and glittering eye—

He holds him with his skinny hand,

Hold off! unhand me, grey-beard loon'

loon: madman

Practice

- 2 The Mariner's tale contains some terrible moments for the sailors. Annotate the following stanzas to show the physical effects the journey has on the Mariner and other sailors.

Extract 1

There passed a **weary** time. Each throat
Was **parched**, and **glazed** each eye.
A weary time! a weary time!
How glazed each weary eye,

With throats **unslaked**, with black lips baked,
We could nor laugh nor **wail**;
Through **utter drought** all **dumb** we stood!
I bit my arm, I sucked the blood,
And cried, A sail! a sail!

weary: tired
parched: dry;
really thirsty
glazed: like glass
unslaked: dry
wail: cry
utter drought:
absolute dryness
dumb: unable to
speak

Challenge

- 3 In the following stanzas, the wedding guest talks to the Mariner about what he has heard so far. Look closely at the reaction of the guest, the appearance of the Mariner and what he says about his feelings. In your notebook, rewrite these stanzas as a story from the guest's point of view. You should start with:

I looked at the old man and trembled with fear.

Extract 2

'I fear thee, ancient Mariner!
I fear thy skinny hand!
And **thou art** long, and **lank**, and brown,
As is the **ribbed** sea-sand.
I fear thee and thy **glittering** eye,
And thy skinny hand, so brown.'—
Fear not, fear not, thou Wedding-Guest!
This body dropt not down.

thou art: you are
lank: thin
ribbed: wrinkled
glittering: shining
brightly

> 9.6 The Rime of the Ancient Mariner 2

Language focus

Poets often use language techniques such as alliteration, rhyme, sibilance and assonance to make their poems sound interesting and memorable when read aloud. These techniques can also be used to support the meanings of the poem. For example, *All in a hot and copper sky* uses assonance. The 'o' sounds in 'hot' and 'copper' seem to emphasise the torture the Mariner is feeling. The sounds are long – they are drawn out when spoken, just like the drawn-out nature of the Mariner's suffering.

Focus

- 1 Explore how rhyme varies in the poem. Annotate the poem to indicate the rhyme scheme, giving rhyming lines the same letter. The first stanza has been done for you.

Extract 3

And soon I heard a roaring wind:
It did not come **anear**;
But with its sound it shook the sails,
That were so thin and **sere**.

And the coming wind did roar more loud,
And the sails did sigh like **sedge**,
And the rain poured down from one black cloud;
The Moon was at its edge.

The thick black cloud was **cleft**, and still
The Moon was at its side:
Like waters shot from some high crag,
The lightning fell with never a jag,
A river steep and wide.

A
B
C
B

anear: close
sere: dry
sedge: a grass-like plant
cleft: split

- 2 Explain what happens in the story when the rhyme scheme changes in the third stanza.

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Practice

- 3 Read the following stanza, in which the Mariner describes watching the water snakes. Highlight examples of sibilance and alliteration in this stanza.

Extract 4

Beyond the shadow of the ship,
I watched the water-snakes:
They moved in tracks of shining white,
And when they **reared**, the **elfish** light
Fell off in **hoary** flakes.

reared: rose up
elfish: mysterious
hoary: white like frost

- 4 Explain what happens in the story during this stanza.

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Challenge

- 5 Explain the effect of sibilance and alliteration in Activity 3. Focus on the atmosphere created by these techniques. Use examples to support your ideas.

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